



(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

Back pain

Back pain, particularly lower back pain, is very common. It usually improves within a few weeks but can sometimes last longer or keep coming back. There are things you can do to help ease the pain.

Causes of back pain

Back pain can have many causes. It's not always obvious what causes it, and it often gets better on its own.

A common cause of back pain is an injury like a pulled muscle (strain (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/sprains-and-strains/)).

Sometimes, medical conditions like a slipped disc (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/slipped-disc/), sciatica (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/sciatica/) (a trapped nerve) or ankylosing spondylitis (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/ankylosing-spondylitis/) can cause back pain.

Very rarely, back pain can be a sign of a serious problem such as a broken bone, cancer or an infection.

See a GP if:

You have back pain and:

- it does not improve after treating it at home for a few weeks
- it's stopping you doing your day-to-day activities
- you're worried about the pain or you're struggling to cope
- you've lost weight without trying to
- there's a lump or swelling in your back, or your back has changed shape
- it does not improve after resting or is worse at night
- it's worse when sneezing, coughing or pooing
- it's coming from the top of your back (between your shoulders), rather than your lower back

Refer yourself for back or joint help

In many areas you may be able to get help, such as physiotherapy, from NHS community musculoskeletal (MSK) services without needing a referral from a GP.

Get NHS help for back or joint problems (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/nhs-services/get-nhs-help-for-back-joint-problems/>)

Ask for an urgent GP appointment or get help from 111 if:

You have back pain and:

- you feel hot, cold, shivery or generally unwell
- it's severe pain that starts suddenly, or it's getting worse quickly

You can call 111 or get help from 111 online (Link: <https://111.nhs.uk/triage/check-your-symptoms>).

Call 999 or go to A&E if:

You have back pain and:

- pain, tingling, weakness or numbness in both legs
- a loss of feeling around your genitals or anus
- changes in your bladder or bowels, such as difficulty peeing, or peeing or pooing yourself
- changes in how your penis or vagina feels during sex, not being able to get or keep an erection, or not being able to orgasm
- chest pain
- it started after a serious accident, such as a car accident

Do not drive to A&E. Ask someone to drive you or call 999 and ask for an ambulance.

Bring any medicines you take with you.

How to ease back pain yourself

Back pain often improves on its own within a few weeks. There are things you can do to help speed up your recovery.

Do

- ✓ stay active and try to continue with your daily activities
- ✓ take anti-inflammatory medicine like ibuprofen (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/ibuprofen-for-adults/) (these may not be suitable for everyone) – paracetamol on its own is not recommended for back pain but it may be used with another painkiller
- ✓ check with a pharmacist or GP if you're unsure about which painkiller is suitable for you
- ✓ use an ice pack (or bag of frozen peas) wrapped in a tea towel to reduce pain and swelling
- ✓ use a heat pack (or hot water bottle) wrapped in a tea towel to relieve joint stiffness or muscle spasms
- ✓ try doing some exercises and stretches for back pain

Don't

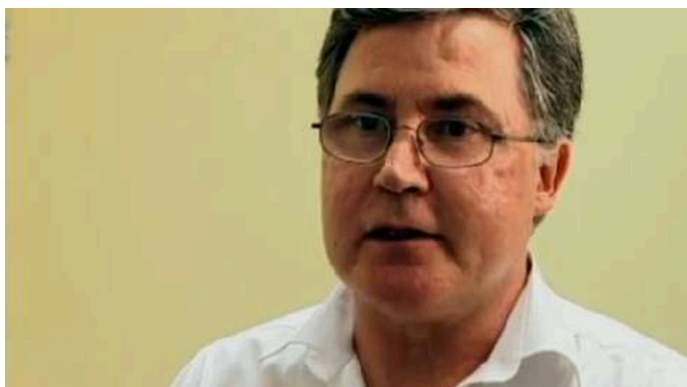
- ✗ do not stay in bed for long periods of time

Exercises and stretches for back pain

There are specific exercises and stretches you can do to help with back pain. But stop if your pain gets worse and see a GP for advice.

Video: Back stretches

In this video, a physiotherapist shows some simple back stretches to help prevent aches and pains.



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Other places to find back pain exercises include:

- NHS back pain pilates video workout (Link: www.nhs.uk/live-well/exercise/pilates-and-yoga/chronic-back-pain-pilates-exercise-video/)
- Chartered Society of Physiotherapy: video exercises for back pain (Link: <https://www.csp.org.uk/conditions/back-pain/video-exercises-back-pain>)

Activities like walking, swimming, yoga and pilates may also help ease back pain.

Treatments for back pain

If your back pain is severe or not getting better, you may be prescribed painkillers.

Other treatments may be recommended if your pain does not get better after a few weeks.

These include:

- group exercise sessions and physiotherapy (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/physiotherapy/)
- manual therapy – where a trained therapist massages and moves the muscles, bones and joints in your back
- cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/cognitive-behavioural-therapy-cbt/) to help you cope with the pain
- a procedure to seal off some of the nerves in your back so they stop sending pain signals (only for long-term lower back pain)

If your back pain is caused by a medical condition like a slipped disc and other treatments have not helped, surgery may be an option.

NIHR



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of Research

Help change lives with research

10 low back pain studies in the UK are currently looking for people like you to take part.

[Find studies now](#)

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